minster also encouraged me to brief him on the macroeconomic situation regularly, and added for good measure, ‘I will always make time for you.’ As I look back, I can say that the prime minister stood by his word. Not only did he always give me time no matter how pressing his schedule or the preoccupations on his mind, but he also seemed to enjoy those meetings.

There was also a strange irony in my appointment as governor. I say this more from hearsay and my own inferences rather than any hard evidence. A year and a half earlier when I was being considered for the position of finance secretary, Chidambaram did not know me and was understandably circumspect about taking me into his team. I gathered that Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, who was acquainted with me from my earlier posting in the ministry of finance in the early ’90s, had to nudge him into it. And now when it came to my appointment as governor, I understand it was Chidambaram who was more actively sponsoring my candidature and it was the prime minister who had to be nudged.

I was touched by the farewell given to me by my colleagues and staff in the DEA. The DEA attracts some of the best civil service talent in the country, and over the previous year and a half, I had built valuable professional relationships and personal friendships. Together, we had launched many initiatives and several were still works in progress. They were proud that one of their own was going as governor, and I was sad to break these bonds, and apprehensive about jumping from the comfort and familiarity of the known to the fear and uncertainty of the unknown.

In the middle of the logistic nightmare of the transition that I was muddling through, Y.V. Reddy, who was also from the IAS, called me up from Mumbai to advise that I should seek voluntary retirement from the IAS before assuming office as governor. At the time, I was fifty-nine and still a year away from superannuation. Reddy’s logic was that I should unequivocally be covered by the code of conduct prescribed for the governor which may be at variance with the IAS code of conduct. When I checked, I was informed by the ‘rules people’ not to bother since I would be deemed to have retired from the IAS as soon as I assumed office as governor. Never in the thirty-five years of my IAS career did I imagine that